

always be necessary. In the process of making a mobile OS using web technologies Mozilla also took a look at what is missing from the web platform; what stops developers from making the web applications for mobiles and making native apps instead. Wherever there was a roadblock, a missing API that stopped an application from getting access to a feature it needed, Mozilla decided to start work on an API and submit it as a web standard for inclusion in all browsers, and participate in its development.

The result of that effort are the Battery API, WebVibration, WebContacts, Settings API, WebSMS, WebTelephony and a number of other web APIs. Many of these APIs have already been implemented in Firefox OS, giving Firefox OS apps access to those native mobile functions. After all, it's not that web applications weren't capable to doing great things, just that they weren't allowed to.

This is where Firefox OS is closer to webOS. Many mobile platforms have embraced the web as an application platform, but with Firefox OS the web IS the native platform of the device.

Every existing web application is already a Firefox OS application. With a little effort it can even become an installable Firefox OS application.

Another important part of Firefox OS is Mozilla's web app store which is intended to make it easy to discover and install web applications on the Firefox OS – and eventually even the desktop – platform. An app doesn't even need to be on Mozilla's store to be installable or using on Firefox OS, all it needs to do is support a manifest for installing the app.

Perhaps the most important thing to understand about Firefox OS is that it is not competing with Android and iOS. It isn't even launching in the US first. Firefox OS is designed to run on low power devices, cheap devices. It is intended to bring smartphones to people who currently only have access to feature phones, and make it possible for them to run applications on their mobile that can enrich their lives.

This is another place where the ubiquity of the web platform comes in. On a platform like the iOS one simply would not find it worthwhile to create an application that has highly local information, such as an app for a local department store. Not many farmers are likely to have iPhones so an app that lets people check market prices of farm produce is less likely to succeed. Even if these apps are entirely free and not profit driven, they are simply not reaching the right people because those people do not have access to the technology being used to deliver it.

Firefox OS intends to be that bridge for those people. Firefox OS's success won't be

*pointers

>>Nuggets of cool code at work



*Firefox Phone OS demoed at CES 2013

>>The initial intended market for devices running B2G is South America and emerging markets. That's why it was demonstrated on a low-end device. The reasoning for the OS is simply to offer choice and competition in the mobile sphere.

<http://dvwix.in/TXFuhv>



*Ubuntu Phone first look

>>Aaron hits the floor at Pepcom's Digital Experience to bring you details on the recently announced Ubuntu platform for smartphones. We wonder if there is enough room to support another mobile operating system.

<http://dvwix.in/105Dvvy>



*Automating Firefox OS

>>Malini Das discusses the challenges in testing Mozilla's new Boot2Gecko operating system, and how they arrived at a solution.

<http://dvwix.in/13yB83j>



*Demo of QNX Car 2 application

>>Sheridan Ethier, automotive engineering manager at QNX Software Systems, gives a feature-by-feature demo of the QNX CAR 2 application platform in the company's latest reference vehicle.

<http://dvwix.in/UHDSrb>

determined by whether it can dethrone iOS or Android, but how many feature phones can it replace with smartphones. How many people finally get access to the web when they never had it before.

If you are itching to try Firefox OS for yourself after reading this, the good news is that there is a version that can run on desktop computers. This is a Firefox OS simulator; it essentially runs Gecko on Windows, Linux or Mac OSX and Gaia on top of that. Firefox OS is currently available under its code name of boot2gecko, and as such what you get is a boot2gecko package with the Firefox OS UI running on a phone sized window on your computer. You can download this package from: <http://ftp.mozilla.org/pub/mozilla.org/b2g/nightly/latest-mozilla-central/>



You can get packages for Windows, Linux and OS X here.

Firefox OS can also be installed as an add-on for Firefox. This is the recommended method as it integrates with Firefox itself, allowing one to push websites and web applications from Firefox to the Firefox OS simulator. That add-on can be acquired from: <https://addons.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/addon/firefox-os-simulator/>

2013 should be an exciting year for mobile platforms. Other than Firefox OS, there is also Tizen that is expected to come to a mobile device this year, and it may also see the re-emergence of webOS and MeeGo as mobile platforms.>

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